

THE GOLD MEDAL WAS A RECOGNITION OF OUR DEDICATION AND HARD WORK

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Mervyn Fernandes

Sometimes it's nice to revisit the good old memories. Back in 1980, I embarked on my first Olympics as a 21-year-old. Naturally, I was excited to be in the Games village in Moscow and soak in every bit of it.

As we entered the village, we were awestruck. People cheered for us and with the presence of so many athletes from across the globe, it felt like a dream come true. **The atmosphere was exhilarating and I still remember every bit of it.** Of course, winning the gold medal for the country — after three not-so memorable editions in 1968, 1972 where India finished third and slumped to a seventh finish in 1976 — was the icing on the cake.

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USSR and Spain proved that we were on track. So eventually, clinching the gold medal was immensely validating.

Under the leadership of Vasudevan Baskaran, the team played as a unit. All of us backed each other through thick and thin and that was evident in our performance on the field. We would hang out together, have meals or

even go to discotheques to take the pressure off and being like a family helped us during those weeks.

Most of us were young with hardly any international experience. In fact, many of us — including myself, (MM) Somaya, (Mohammed) Shahid, Zafar (Iqbal) — were playing for the first time in the same team at the international level and the seasoned Baskaran ensured that the



People often ask me how we handled pressure and to be honest, when you are young, you do not think about all those factors. You just train well and give your best and Baskaran advised us to play our natural game.